

2026

Social & Modern Studies

Grade 9 NCE — **Paper 2 of 4**

Focus: Economic Development • Social Issues

Duration: 2 hours **Total Marks:** 100

Candidate Name: _____

Class / Form: _____ Index No.: _____

Instructions to Candidates

1. This paper has **four sections**: A, B, C, and D.
2. Answer **ALL** questions in Sections A, B, and D.
3. In Section C, answer **ALL THREE** structured questions.
4. Write your answers in the spaces provided.
5. For Section A, tick (✓) **ONE** box only per question.
6. Use blue or black ink. Pencil may be used for diagrams only.
7. The marks for each question are shown in brackets [].
8. Calculators are **NOT** permitted.

Section	A — MCQ	B — Source	C — Structured	D — Essay	Total
Maximum marks	20	30	30	20	100
Marks scored					

SECTION A — Multiple Choice Questions [20 marks — 1 mark each] Tick ONE box only per question.

1. Which sector formed the backbone of the Mauritian economy at independence in 1968? [1]
- ☐ A Tourism and hospitality
 - ☐ B Financial services
 - ☐ C Sugar production and agriculture
 - ☐ D Information and communication technology
2. The Export Processing Zone (EPZ) established in Mauritius in the 1970s primarily focused on: [1]
- ☐ A Sugar refining and export
 - ☐ B Light manufacturing especially textiles and garments for export
 - ☐ C Deep-sea fishing and canning
 - ☐ D Technology software development
3. Which of the following best describes the role of tourism in Mauritius's economy? [1]
- ☐ A It is a minor sector with limited contribution to GDP
 - ☐ B It is a key pillar earning significant foreign exchange and creating employment
 - ☐ C It is declining and being replaced entirely by manufacturing
 - ☐ D It contributes mainly through domestic tourism spending
4. Mauritius has developed as a major financial services centre. Which of the following best explains WHY? [1]
- ☐ A Its large natural resources and mining industry
 - ☐ B Its political instability making it attractive to foreign investors
 - ☐ C Its stable legal framework, favourable tax treaties, and skilled workforce
 - ☐ D Its central location in the Pacific Ocean
5. What is meant by 'economic diversification'? [1]
- ☐ A Reducing the number of trading partners a country deals with
 - ☐ B Expanding an economy into a broader range of industries and sectors
 - ☐ C Concentrating all economic activity on one dominant export
 - ☐ D Distributing economic output equally among all citizens

6. The Gross Domestic Product (GDP) of a country measures: [1]
- ☐ A The total wealth held by all citizens
 - ☐ B The total value of goods and services produced within a country in a given year
 - ☐ C The total amount of money in government bank accounts
 - ☐ D The value of all exported goods in a year
7. The Human Development Index (HDI) measures a country's development using which THREE indicators? [1]
- ☐ A Military strength, exports, and GDP per capita
 - ☐ B Life expectancy, education, and income (GNI per capita)
 - ☐ C Population size, trade balance, and foreign debt
 - ☐ D Agricultural output, urbanisation, and literacy
8. Which of the following is an example of a social benefit of economic development? [1]
- ☐ A Increased pollution from industrial activity
 - ☐ B Rising inequality between rich and poor
 - ☐ C Improved access to healthcare, education, and housing
 - ☐ D Depletion of natural resources
9. In Mauritius, the 'Nine-Year Continuous Basic Education' (NCE) scheme aims to: [1]
- ☐ A Make secondary school education compulsory and free up to Grade 9
 - ☐ B Allow students to leave school after Grade 6
 - ☐ C Charge fees for primary education to raise revenue
 - ☐ D Limit the number of students in each school
10. Absolute poverty is best defined as: [1]
- ☐ A Having less wealth than the average person in society
 - ☐ B Being unable to afford basic necessities such as food, shelter, and clothing
 - ☐ C Earning below the national minimum wage
 - ☐ D Living in a rural rather than urban area
11. Which Mauritian government programme provides income support to the most vulnerable households? [1]
- ☐ A The Export Processing Zone Act
 - ☐ B The Social Aid and Social Register of Mauritius
 - ☐ C The Offshore Business Activities Act

☐ D The Tourism Promotion Authority

12. The glass ceiling is a term used to describe:

[1]

- ☐ A Laws that prevent women from owning property
- ☐ B The informal barriers that prevent women and minorities from reaching senior positions
- ☐ C The maximum salary that public sector workers may earn
- ☐ D Government-imposed limits on executive pay

13. Gender equality in education means:

[1]

- ☐ A Having separate schools for boys and girls
- ☐ B Girls receiving the same quality and opportunities in education as boys
- ☐ C Teaching the same subjects to all students regardless of ability
- ☐ D Requiring equal numbers of male and female teachers

14. Universal healthcare means that:

[1]

- ☐ A Only the wealthy can access private medical care
- ☐ B Healthcare is provided only in cities and towns
- ☐ C All citizens have access to healthcare services regardless of ability to pay
- ☐ D Doctors are employed directly by the government

15. Non-Communicable Diseases (NCDs) in Mauritius include:

[1]

- ☐ A Malaria and cholera
- ☐ B Tuberculosis and typhoid
- ☐ C Diabetes, cardiovascular disease, and hypertension
- ☐ D Influenza and dengue fever

16. The Gini coefficient is used to measure:

[1]

- ☐ A A country's total economic output
- ☐ B Income inequality within a country
- ☐ C The number of people living below the poverty line
- ☐ D The gap between urban and rural populations

17. Which of the following is a cause of poverty in developing countries?

[1]

- ☐ A High levels of education among the workforce
- ☐ B Strong democratic institutions
- ☐ C Lack of access to credit, education, and employment opportunities
- ☐ D High levels of foreign direct investment

18. The Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) that relate to social issues include: [1]
- ☐ A SDG 1 (No Poverty), SDG 3 (Good Health), and SDG 4 (Quality Education)
 - ☐ B SDG 7 (Affordable Energy), SDG 9 (Infrastructure), and SDG 13 (Climate Action)
 - ☐ C SDG 14 (Life Below Water) and SDG 15 (Life on Land)
 - ☐ D SDG 8 (Decent Work) and SDG 17 (Partnerships)
19. Which of the following best defines 'social mobility'? [1]
- ☐ A The ability of people to move between countries freely
 - ☐ B The movement of people from rural to urban areas
 - ☐ C The ability of individuals to move to a higher or lower social or economic position
 - ☐ D The use of mobile phones for social media
20. The concept of 'sustainable economic development' means that development: [1]
- ☐ A Focuses entirely on increasing GDP without other considerations
 - ☐ B Meets the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet theirs
 - ☐ C Relies solely on foreign investment rather than local resources
 - ☐ D Should be managed entirely by international organisations

SECTION B — Source-Based Questions [30 marks] Answer ALL questions in this section.

SOURCE A

Mauritius Tourism Sector — Key Statistics (2023)

Indicator	Value
Total tourist arrivals	1.3 million
Tourism earnings (USD billion)	2.1
Tourism as % of GDP	~18%
Direct jobs in tourism	72,000+
Top source market	France (21%)
Average tourist spend per visit (USD)	1,620

Source: Tourism Authority of Mauritius / Statistics Mauritius, 2023

21.

- (a) Using Source A, state **TWO** ways in which tourism contributes to the Mauritian economy.

[2]

- (b) Using Source A, explain why tourism is considered one of the most important 'pillars' of the Mauritian economy. Support your answer with data from the table.

[4]

- (c) Explain ONE advantage and ONE disadvantage of Mauritius relying heavily on tourism as a major sector of its economy.

[4]

SOURCE B

The Export Processing Zone (EPZ) was established in Mauritius in 1971 as a strategy to attract foreign investment and create employment by offering tax incentives, duty-free importation of raw materials, and streamlined regulations for export-oriented manufacturers. Primarily focused on the textile and garment industry, the EPZ transformed Mauritius from a monoculture sugar economy into a manufacturing nation within a decade. Women made up over 70% of the EPZ workforce, marking a significant shift in gender roles and women's economic participation. At its peak in the late 1980s and 1990s, the EPZ employed over 90,000 workers and generated more than 50% of Mauritius's export earnings. However, the removal of preferential trade agreements and competition from lower-cost Asian manufacturers led to a sharp decline from the early 2000s. Today, Mauritius has shifted focus towards higher value-added sectors such as ICT, financial services, and biotechnology.

Adapted from: Bank of Mauritius / Ministry of Finance, Economic History of Mauritius

22.

- (a) Using Source B, identify **TWO** incentives that Mauritius offered to attract manufacturers to the EPZ.

[2]

- (b) Using Source B, explain how the EPZ contributed to economic development AND to social change in Mauritius.

[4]

- (c) Using Source B and your own knowledge, explain why the EPZ declined from the early 2000s and what lessons this holds for economic development strategy. [4]

SOURCE C

"Despite impressive economic progress since independence, Mauritius continues to face significant social challenges. Income inequality remains a concern, with the richest 20% of households earning approximately seven times more than the poorest 20%. Poverty is concentrated among specific groups including elderly persons living alone, single-parent families, and residents of certain peri-urban communities. Access to quality education is not yet equal: children from disadvantaged backgrounds are more likely to underperform in examinations and less likely to pursue tertiary education. Gender inequality in the labour market persists, with women earning on average 16% less than men for equivalent work. However, government social programmes — including free education, free healthcare, social housing, and income support — have kept the absolute poverty rate below 1%. The challenge is now to build a more equitable society where all citizens share in the country's prosperity."

Adapted from: National Human Development Report, Mauritius, 2024

23.

- (a) Using Source C, identify **TWO** groups that are most vulnerable to poverty in Mauritius. [2]

- (b) Using Source C, explain the difference between absolute poverty and relative poverty. How does Mauritius's situation reflect this distinction? [4]

- (c) Using Source C and your own knowledge, explain how government social programmes in Mauritius have helped to address poverty and inequality. What further action might be needed? [4]

SECTION C — Structured Essay Questions [30 marks] Answer ALL THREE questions.

- 24. Describe the role of the tourism industry in the economic development of Mauritius.**

[10]

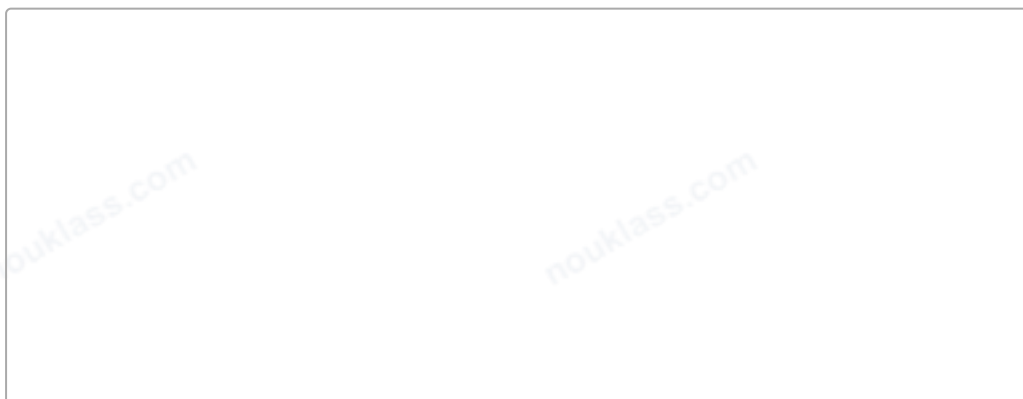
In your answer refer to: how tourism developed; its contribution to GDP and employment; its links to other sectors; and its challenges and vulnerabilities.



- 25. Explain how the Export Processing Zone (EPZ) contributed to the industrialisation and economic transformation of Mauritius.**

[10]

Consider: why it was established; what it achieved economically and socially; why it declined; and what replaced it.



26. Discuss the social challenges of poverty and inequality in Mauritius and evaluate the effectiveness of measures taken to address them.

[10]

Consider: causes of poverty; its effects on individuals and families; government programmes; and remaining challenges.

SECTION D — Extended Writing and Evaluation [20 marks] Answer the COMPULSORY question below.

27. "Gender equality is essential for the sustainable development of Mauritius."

[20]

Using your knowledge and the evidence from Section B, write a well-organised essay in which you:

- Define gender equality and explain why it matters for development
- Describe the progress Mauritius has made towards gender equality in education, health, and the economy
- Analyse the barriers to gender equality that remain in Mauritius
- Evaluate the extent to which gender equality has been achieved and what further steps are needed

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Mark Scheme — Paper 2: Economic Development / Social Issues

This mark scheme provides **indicative content**. Credit any well-reasoned response that demonstrates knowledge and understanding. Exact wording is not required.

Section A — MCQ Answers

1. C — Sugar production 2. B — Textiles and garments 3. B — Key pillar earning foreign exchange 4. C — Stable legal framework and tax treaties 5. B — Expanding into broader range of industries	6. B — Total value of goods and services 7. B — Life expectancy, education, income 8. C — Improved access to healthcare and education 9. A — Free compulsory schooling to Grade 9 10. B — Unable to afford basic necessities
11. B — Social Aid and Social Register 12. B — Informal barriers to senior positions 13. B — Same quality and opportunities in education 14. C — All citizens have access regardless of ability to pay 15. C — Diabetes, cardiovascular disease, hypertension	16. B — Income inequality 17. C — Lack of credit, education, and employment 18. A — SDG 1, 3, 4 19. C — Movement between social/economic positions 20. B — Meets present needs without compromising future generations

Q	Indicative Content	Marks
21(a)	Any TWO from Source A: earns USD 2.1bn in foreign exchange; contributes ~18% of GDP; provides 72,000+ direct jobs. Award 1 mark each.	2
21(b)	Large share of GDP (~18%); earns over USD 2bn in foreign exchange; employs 72,000+ directly (more indirectly in supply chains); France as top market shows international exposure. Award marks for using specific data with explanation.	4
21(c)	<i>Advantage</i> : generates significant foreign exchange, creates employment, stimulates other sectors (agriculture, transport, retail). <i>Disadvantage</i> : vulnerable to global shocks (COVID-19 2020 wiped out sector); seasonal; dependent on long-haul tourists from a few markets; can lead to environmental pressures. Award 2 marks per point: 1 for identification, 1 for explanation.	4
22(a)	Any TWO from Source B: tax incentives; duty-free importation of raw materials; streamlined regulations. Award 1 mark each.	2
22(b)	<i>Economic</i> : transformed Mauritius from monoculture (sugar) to manufacturing within a decade; at peak, 90,000+ workers, 50%+ of export earnings; diversified the economy. <i>Social</i> : women made up 70%+ of EPZ workforce, transforming gender roles and increasing women's economic independence. Award up to 2 marks per dimension.	4
22(c)	<i>Decline</i> : removal of preferential trade agreements (Multi-Fibre Arrangement end 2004); cheaper competition from China, Bangladesh, Cambodia. <i>Lesson</i> : economies dependent on preferential access are vulnerable; need to diversify towards	4

	higher value-added sectors (ICT, finance, biotech) that are less easily undercut. Award marks for accurate cause plus relevant lesson.	
23(a)	Any TWO from Source C: elderly persons living alone; single-parent families; residents of peri-urban communities. Award 1 mark each.	2
23(b)	<i>Absolute poverty</i> : inability to afford basic necessities (food, shelter, clothing) — Mauritius absolute poverty rate below 1%. <i>Relative poverty</i> : having significantly less than the average — richest 20% earn ~7x poorest 20%, showing relative inequality even as absolute poverty is low. Full marks for clear distinction applied to Mauritius context.	4
23(c)	<i>Success of programmes</i> : free education kept school enrolment high; free healthcare reduced infant mortality; social housing assisted low-income families; income support kept absolute poverty below 1%. <i>Further action</i> : tackle relative inequality; close gender pay gap; improve quality of education in disadvantaged areas; increase women in senior roles; address NCD burden. Award marks for specific examples and balanced evaluation.	4
24	<i>Band 4 (8–10)</i> : Detailed account of tourism's development, multiple data points, analysis of multiplier effects, awareness of vulnerability to shocks, balance of strengths and weaknesses, well-organised. <i>Band 3 (5–7)</i> : Good knowledge of 2–3 aspects, some analysis. <i>Band 2 (2–4)</i> : Basic; descriptive. <i>Key content</i> : rapid growth from 1970s; luxury positioning; contribution to GDP and employment; links to food supply, transport, construction; COVID-19 as example of vulnerability; over-dependence risk.	10
25	<i>Content</i> : established 1971 to attract FDI and diversify from sugar; garment/textile focus; tax incentives and duty-free imports; women's employment; peak 90,000 workers; decline from 2000s due to loss of trade preferences and Asian competition; transition to ICT, financial services, biotech. <i>Higher marks</i> : evaluate the EPZ experience — what worked, what were the limits, how it informs future economic strategy.	10
26	<i>Content</i> : causes — unequal asset distribution, limited access to credit and education, single parenthood, old age, unemployment; effects — poor nutrition, limited life chances, health problems, social exclusion; programmes — Social Aid, free education, free healthcare, social housing, minimum wage; evaluation — absolute poverty low but relative inequality persists; gender pay gap; regional disparities; NCD burden disproportionately affects the poor.	10
27	Extended essay — 20 marks. Level 4 (16–20): Sustained, analytical essay with definition, evidence of progress (women in education outperforming men, access to healthcare, EPZ role), barriers (pay gap 16%, glass ceiling, domestic responsibilities, cultural norms), and evaluative conclusion with specific next steps. Level 3 (11–15): Good argument, mostly balanced. Level 2 (6–10): Some relevant points, limited analysis. Level 1 (1–5): Very limited or largely irrelevant.	20

